



The Future of Work

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Questions for Reflection

To prepare for a substantive exchange, we invite you to reflect on a set of deliberately provocative questions. They surface assumptions, challenge familiar narratives, and frame the real dilemmas boards are now facing. There are no simple answers – which is precisely why peer dialogue matters.

- Your organisation has likely announced a significant AI investment. But does the board have visibility of its composition? Specifically: what proportion is allocated to reskilling and has the board ever seen an actual breakdown of that investment? An AI investment without a proportionate reskilling line is not a transformation budget. It is a cost reduction exercise that will eventually undermine its own returns.
- AI is almost certainly already operating inside your organisation. The question is not whether it is there, it is whether your governance is. Can a human in your organisation overrule an AI-assisted decision in a high-risk process? Should they be able to? And if it has happened, was that escalation path deliberately designed with named accountability, or did it occur by accident? The difference between those two answers is the difference between governance and exposure.
- How confident are you that your C-suite is genuinely equipped to lead in a world where the most consequential decisions will increasingly be made at the intersection of human judgment and machine output? Not to use AI tools, but to lead organisations through the irreversible redesign of how work, authority, and accountability are distributed between humans and agents?
- When did AI last appear on your board agenda and in what form? As a technology briefing, a risk register item, or a substantive governance



question with the CPO and CTO presenting together? The framing of that answer tells you more about your board's readiness than any maturity framework.

- Five years from now, the organisations that failed the human transition will not have lacked AI tools. They will have lacked the board courage to ask management the questions that were uncomfortable in 2026. Which question is your board currently not asking and what is making it easier not to ask it?

Introduction

Most organisations have deployed AI tools. Far fewer have answered the harder question: when AI acts autonomously on behalf of the organisation, what remains distinctly human – and how do boards ensure that the transition is led, not merely absorbed?

Workforce transformation is not a technology project. It is a governance challenge. The distance between an organisation that captures AI's full value and one that loses talent, trust, and institutional knowledge in the process is determined less by what AI systems are deployed than by the leadership and board decisions made around them.

Starting with the maturity journey, because before we can talk about where AI and work are going, we need to agree on where your organisation actually stands today.

The Maturity Journey: Where Is Your Organisation?

Enterprises do not become agentic by declaration. Most listed European companies sit between Stage 1 and Stage 2 and progressing through the maturity journey requires leadership intent, reskilling investment, and board governance far more than technology.

What is at stake in that progression is not job elimination. History shows technology recomposes work rather than destroying it, but whether organisations lead that re-composition deliberately or arrive at it by default.

Stage 1 AI-Adjacent	Stage 2 AI-Enabled	Stage 3 AI-Integrated	Stage 4 Agentic by Design
Isolated tools. Individual productivity gains. No structural change.	AI embedded in workflows. Efficiency gains measurable. Skills gaps emerging.	Roles redesigned around human-agent collaboration. Reskilling active. Board receiving AI performance data.	Agents operating across functions. Talent redeployed. Governance frameworks live. (Salesforce today)

Just a few key data points to consider:

- **Adecco:** 59% of the global workforce will require reskilling by 2030 (Adecco Global Workforce of the Future Report)
- **WEF:** 39% of existing core skills will be replaced or substantially upgraded by 2030; 14% of new jobs will emerge from AI and macro-trends
- **Salesforce:** 100% of employees now work alongside AI agents; over 500,000 hours of work redirected; 1 million customer support requests handled autonomously

"AI alone does not create value. People do. The technology is the multiplier; the human is the engine."

Human Value in an Agentic World: The Multiplier and the Frontier

Organisations extracting most value from agentic AI are not those that cut headcount most aggressively. They are those that most deliberately freed their people to operate at a higher level. Reskilling is not a cost of AI adoption; it is the mechanism by which AI adoption generates returns. Yet there is a hard limit: AI can master skills faster and more consistently than individuals, yet it cannot want something, exercise genuine moral reasoning, or be inspired. The employees thriving most are not the most technically proficient – they are the most adaptable, curious, and capable of working at the intersection of human judgment and machine output.

"AI can process sentiment. It cannot feel it. It can optimise a decision. It cannot own one."

The Human in the Loop: Reassuring Phrase, Difficult Reality

'Human in the loop' is frequently invoked but rarely rigorously defined. There is a critical difference between a human who genuinely interrogates an agent's output and one who rubber-stamps it under time pressure. The risk accumulates quietly; in gradual deskilling, eroded oversight capacity, and diffused accountability.

"The most dangerous moment in AI governance is not when the system fails visibly. It is when it succeeds so consistently that the humans stop paying attention."

The Leadership Required in a New World of Work

The transition to an agentic enterprise is as much a leadership challenge as a technology one. The distance between Stage 2 and Stage 4 on the maturity journey is primarily a leadership, culture, and governance gap and not a technology gap. Leaders must be capable of holding ambiguity, driving change at pace, and maintaining trust as roles are redesigned. Adecco research identifies 'leadership confidence in managing human-AI collaboration' as a key differentiator between organisations that capture AI value and those that do not. Ultimately the boards must ask whether their C-suite has the right leadership profile for an agentic era.

What Boards Must Now Govern "AND" what should keep you awake at night

The governance agenda is more specific and urgent than boards have generally acknowledged. Four dimensions cannot be delegated entirely to management:

- **Reskilling:** AI investment without proportionate reskilling is a cost reduction exercise that will undermine its own gains.
- **Human-in-the-loop standard:** Define 'human oversight' in operational terms for every high-risk AI-assisted process with named accountabilities and regular audit.
- **Talent and culture:** Press CHROs on whether the organisation's talent strategy is oriented towards adaptability, ethical reasoning, and creative vision, then the capabilities AI cannot replicate.



- **Governance structure:** AI as a standing board item, not a periodic briefing. CPO and CTO presenting together. Regular structured account of how the human-agent balance is performing.

If you know a peer whose perspective would enrich the room, we encourage you to bring them along – to confirm your place or register a colleague, please write to our team.

We look forward to your participation on 15 June.

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